

What is it possible to know? From Spinoza's Perspective

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This essay will primarily focus on Spinoza and how Spinoza differentiates himself from Hume. For starters, Spinoza believes in the idea that ordinary pursuits lead to a sense of “hollowness”¹, and instead we should seek to find this “true good”² which provides a “continuous and supreme joy to all eternity”³. Spinoza believes in this *true good* but acknowledges that attaining the true good is uncertain, though if it were to be attained it must be attained through the fourth mode of perception which is perceiving a thing “through its essence alone”⁴. As such, the question of “what is it possible to know” is held in extremely high regards for Spinoza because it lays the very foundation for finding the *true good*. For Spinoza, the significance of this question lies in its power to reorient the whole of philosophy toward human perfection. He insists that we must first “devise a method of emending the intellect and of purifying it, as far as is feasible at the outset, so that it may succeed in understanding things without error and as well as possible”⁵. Additionally, Spinoza sees the question as urgent because most people never examine their own cognitive habits. They rely on hearsay or casual experience, and as a result they “have come to doubt even their true perceptions,”⁶ confusing dreams with waking life. By investigating the limits and powers of the intellect, we can free ourselves from such confusion and deliberately direct the mind toward what is eternal. The significance of “what is it possible to know?” is therefore that it marks the beginning of a disciplined pursuit of the highest good, one which transforms both thought and life.

Spinoza believes that the only way one could possibly achieve this eternal *true good* is by loving eternal things. Spinoza argues that “all happiness or unhappiness depends solely on the quality of the object to which we are bound by love”⁷, arguing that the only way to be truly happy forever is by loving eternal things. Spinoza says that “love towards a thing eternal and infinite feeds the mind with joy alone, unmixed with any sadness”⁸. Thus, this leads cleanly into what Spinoza believes is possible to know since he believes that understanding the nature of a thing itself is something eternal. Spinoza believes that the essence of a thing can only be perceived through one mode of perception, thus that mode of perception is the only way in which one could attain the *true good*. Spinoza breaks acquisition of knowledge into the following 4 categories:

¹Baruch Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, in The Collected Works of Spinoza, vol. 1, ed. and trans. Edwin Curley (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1985), p. 233.

²Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, p. 233.

³Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, p. 233.

⁴Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, p. 237.

⁵Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, p. 236.

⁶Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, p. 245.

⁷Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, p. 234-235.

⁸Spinoza, Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect, p. 235.

“If I examine them carefully, they [how we perceive things] can all be classified under four headings.

1. There is the perception we have from hearsay, or from some sign conventionally agreed upon.
2. There is the perception we have from casual experience; that is, experience that is not determined by intellect, but is so called because it chances thus to occur, and we have experienced nothing else that contradicts it, so that it remains in our minds unchallenged.
3. There is the perception we have when the essence of a thing is inferred from another thing, but not adequately. This happens either when we infer a cause from some effect or when an inference is made from some universal which is made from some universal which is always accompanied by some property
4. Finally, there is the perception we have when a thing is perceived through its essence alone, or through knowledge of its proximate cause.”⁹

Spinoza believes strongly that all knowledge is attained through these categories. Not to reiterate too much from my past essay, but the first category is knowledge learned from others which is insufficient because the knower knows only that another believes it to be true. The second is causal experience which is also insufficient since this category is good at generating particulars which doesn’t necessarily translate into generating universals since one’s causal experiences does not dictate the experiences of others. The third category is an attempt at perceiving the essence of things from its relation to another thing, which Spinoza argues is also inadequate since one does not necessarily understand the connection between the things. Thus lastly is the perception of the essence of a thing through its essence alone, which is the only way one can hope to reach the *true good* since it is the only mode of perception which can truly attain the essence of things. According to Spinoza, only the fourth mode “comprehends the adequate essence of the thing, and is without danger of error”¹⁰.

Spinoza also emphasizes that the intellect, when properly directed, can know things “not so much under duration as under some form of eternity.”¹¹ This means that true knowledge is not about contingent facts that could be otherwise; it is about the necessary structure of reality. By grasping essences and their causal relations, the mind “reproduces in thought the reality of Nature.”¹² Thus, for Spinoza, it is possible to know the eternal principles that govern all things, and this knowledge is the very content of the true good.

David Hume’s answer to the question of knowledge stands is vastly different than Spinoza’s. Hume famously divides all objects of reason into “relations of ideas” (certain but uninformative

⁹Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, p. 237.

¹⁰Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, p. 239.

¹¹Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, p. 261, The 5th Property of the Intellect.

¹²Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, p. 257.

about the world) and “matters of fact” (contingent and known only through experience).¹³ He argues that we never perceive any necessary connection between cause and effect; instead, we merely observe constant conjunction and develop a habit of expecting one event to follow another. “Custom, then, is the great guide of human life,” Hume writes. “Without the influence of custom, we should be entirely ignorant of every matter of fact beyond what is immediately present to the memory and senses.”¹⁴ For Hume, the belief that the future will resemble the past is not grounded in reason but in a natural instinct.

These two perspectives couldn’t be more different than each other, Spinoza specifically believes that cause and effect relations and lived experiences cannot be possibly sufficient for understanding the nature of the world whereas that is Hume’s exact philosophy. Another key distinction is that Spinoza believes the essence of things should almost come “intuitively, without going through any procedure”¹⁵, which implies that a single instance of a thing is able to grasp its essence, whereas Hume would find that incredibly insufficient. Hume’s ideals are vastly centered on customs, that since things happen repeatedly they are likely to continue to repeat. Thus, for Hume, a single instance of any relation is incredibly insufficient to attempt to understand anything about the relation.

Thus, Spinoza treats the question “what is it possible to know?” as the very foundation for the *true good* and how to live a good life. He believes that we can know the essences of things through grasping the essences themselves, which is essential for attaining the *true good* for eternal happiness. Whereas Hume limits knowledge to relations of ideas and matters of fact which are grounded in custom, denying that we can ever truly grasp the essences of things themselves.

¹³David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, ed. Tom L. Beauchamp (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), p. 28.

¹⁴Hume, *Enquiry*, p. 45

¹⁵Spinoza, *Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect*, p. 238.